

GANAPATHI IN THE VIDEO FOOTAGE (BELOW); NAXALS AT A TRAINING CAMP IN JHARKHAND



DELHI | The Face of Terror

India's Maoist terror finally has a face. For nearly three decades after he went underground as a young Naxalite revolutionary in Andhra Pradesh, nobody knew what Muppala Lakshmana Rao, 59, looked like. It was easy to assume the Indian Maoists were running on auto-pilot from their jungle redoubts. Until now. For the first time, the Home Ministry has released video footage of 'Ganapathi', leader of the nearly 10,000 armed guerrillas he directly controls. Recorded at a Maoist meeting deep within the Dandakaranya forests in Chhattisgarh and Jharkhand two years ago, the footage was part of Naxal propaganda. Fittingly, the same footage is now part of the Government's subtle propaganda to name and shame Naxal leaders and their supporters. The recording shows a swarthy man with a shock of black dyed hair wearing a Mao-style buttoned up green military uniform addressing armed Maoists from a pulpit. Flanking him are pictures of Lenin, Stalin and Chairman Mao Tse Tung. Ganapathi had succeeded Kondapalli Seetharamaiah as general secretary of the People's War Group in 1991. In the video, he is every bit the former schoolteacher from Andhra Pradesh's Karimnagar district and not the monster who could well be responsible for the deaths of thousands of civilians and security personnel over the past decade.

by Sandeep Unnithan

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thousand armed Naxal guerrillas are controlled by Ganapathi. The Maoists are active in 223 of the 604 districts of India.